That year, the QuickBooks score dropped 20 points, the first time the company had ever moved the needle with the Net Promoter Score. That 20-point drop resulted in significant losses for Intuit and was embarrassing for the company—all because customer feedback came too late in the process, allowing no time to iterate.

Intuit's senior management, including the general manager of the small business division and the head of small business accounting, recognized the need for change. To their credit, they tasked Greg with driving that change. His mission: to achieve startup speed for the development and deployment of QuickBooks.

Year Two: Muscle Memory

The next chapter of this story illustrates how hard it is to build an adaptive organization. Greg set out to change the QuickBooks development process by using four principles:

1. Smaller teams. Shift from large teams with uniform functional roles to smaller, fully engaged teams whose members take on different roles.
2. Achieve shorter cycle times.
3. Faster customer feedback, testing both whether it crashes customers' computers and the performance of new features/customer experience.
4. Enable and empower teams to make fast and courageous decisions.

On the surface, these goals seem to be aligned with the methods and principles described in previous chapters, but Greg's second year with QuickBooks was not a marked success. For example, he decreed that the team would move to a midyear release milestone, effectively cutting the cycle time and batch size in half. However, this was not successful. Through sheer determination, the team tried valiantly to get an alpha release out in January. However, the problems that afflict large-batch development were still present.